

Chapter 54-1: 欲盖弥彰 (Trying to Cover Up Only Makes Things More Obvious)

"What?" Ning Fuyi thought she had misheard.

"Take them off, get in." Chu Qingqiu repeated once more, turning her body away, "I won't look at you."

Ning Fuyi let out an "oh" and reached to remove her clothes, walking barefoot to the edge of the water pool. She tested the temperature with her toes—the icy cold penetrated deep into her bones through her skin, making her shiver.

She looked back. Chu Qingqiu had her back turned and hadn't moved at all. Ning Fuyi had no choice but to grit her teeth and step one leg into the water. The bone-chilling water numbed half her body.

After her entire body was submerged in the water, the cold energy flowed through her extraordinary meridians¹, and Ning Fuyi's mind became unusually clear.

"I'm ready, Divine Venerable." Ning Fuyi spoke. Only then did Chu Qingqiu turn around. With a wave of her hand, a white silk ribbon fell over Ning Fuyi's eyes, completely blocking her vision.

Unable to see, her hearing became extremely sensitive. The sound of wind and the gurgling of spring water became incredibly clear. She heard the rustling of clothes and couldn't help but sink deeper into the pool.

Originally, her shoulders were still exposed, but with this movement, only her head remained above water.

Someone else entered the pool. Ripples spread across the water surface toward her, washing over her skin. Ning Fuyi caught the woman's fragrance—without the barrier of clothing, this scent was even more rich and intoxicating.

Her hands underwater couldn't help but pinch her own thigh, restraining herself from imagining how Chu Qingqiu looked right now.

In her previous life, it wasn't as if no one had tried to seduce her. Besides the carefully groomed young men, there were also women like Du Baishuang—all with slender waists and full hips, perfect figures.

But no matter how beautiful they were, how fragrant their scent, or how little clothing they wore, in Ning Fuyi's eyes they were nothing more than a ball of flesh with four limbs attached—completely without attraction.

This had led Ning Fuyi to once think she was naturally missing that particular string, making her a good candidate for cultivating the Path of Ruthlessness².

Yet now, just hearing some sounds and catching a hint of fragrance, she felt her face burning hot.

Water flowed toward her as Chu Qingqiu's body drew closer. Their skin might touch at any moment underwater, and Ning Fuyi's body involuntarily leaned back until her spine pressed against the ice-cold pool wall.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertip suddenly touched her forehead. As if struck by lightning, Ning Fuyi's vision flashed, the surrounding scenery disappeared, and her consciousness sank into an endless sea of consciousness.

This time, Ning Fuyi could see her surroundings clearly even with closed eyes. She stood on a hillside where the grass had just sprouted, so tender it could be squeezed for water. Even stepping on it barefoot didn't feel uncomfortable.

At the top of the hillside stood two towering trees with green bark and lush branches, but they had only trunks and branches—not a single leaf. Each extending branch bore fruit.

One tree bore red fruit, the other black.

Ning Fuyi was greatly surprised. But just as she took two steps forward to get a closer look, the ground beneath her feet began to shake violently. White light flashed before her eyes, her consciousness was expelled from the sea of consciousness, and the icy pool water once again enveloped her body.

As Ning Fuyi stood there bewildered, her cheek was splashed with something warm. Her heart immediately sank—she tore off the white silk covering her eyes and pulled up Chu Qingqiu, who had already fallen into the pool.

"Divine Venerable!" she cried in shock. The previously clear pool water was now mixed with traces of blood, and the corner of Chu Qingqiu's mouth was also stained red. She tried to push Ning Fuyi away with open arms but had no strength. Instead, she was held tightly by Ning Fuyi, fixed in place in the pool.

Chu Qingqiu's skin seemed even colder than the frigid pool. Panic inexplicably filled Ning Fuyi's heart. She grabbed clothes from the shore and hastily put them on both of them, then lifted Chu Qingqiu and leaped high into the air.

They landed beside the pool with a splash like ocean waves, both dripping wet. Chu Qingqiu couldn't stand steady and collapsed as soon as she touched the ground. Ning Fuyi quickly crouched down with her, pulling the cold body into her arms.

"What happened?" Ning Fuyi had no time to dry herself. Frowning coldly, she raised her hand to summon immortal power and probe deep into Chu Qingqiu's body.

Her immortal meridians were in chaos—symptoms of injury.

This shouldn't be possible. She had only used the cold pool to examine her own sea of consciousness—how could this cause such injury?

Chu Qingqiu seemed unable to speak much for the moment. Her clothes clung to her body completely. She grabbed Ning Fuyi's lapel: "Return to Jingshan Palace."

When Chu Qingqiu spoke, her body was still trembling, the color drained from her face until she was pale as if she might shatter at a touch.

Ning Fuyi dared not delay any longer. She immediately lifted her horizontally in her arms, her body transforming into flowing light. The next instant, they landed beneath the pavilions of Jingshan Palace.

Fortunately, there were few people in Jingshan Palace, so no one saw them in this state. Ning Fuyi ran up the stairs and placed Chu Qingqiu, who had become as soft as water, on the bed.

Then she waved her hand above their bodies, and the water on both Chu Qingqiu and herself vanished without a trace.

Footnotes:

- 奇经八脉 (Extraordinary Meridians)** - In traditional Chinese medicine and cultivation novels, these refer to the eight extraordinary vessels or meridians through which qi (life energy) flows in the body.
- 无情道 (Path of Ruthlessness)** - A cultivation path that involves severing emotional attachments and desires to achieve spiritual advancement.